

The Narrative of the Deeds of Moonlight

Candraprabhā Avadāna · Toh 348 · Derge Kangyur

ཟླ་བ་འཛིན་ཀྱི་ལྷོ་ས་པ་བརྒྱུད་པ་

The Candraprabha Avadāna, known in Tibetan as the Narrative of the Deeds of Moonlight, is a canonical Buddhist narrative belonging to the avadāna genre — a class of text that recounts legendary deeds and their karmic consequences, typically to illustrate the workings of cause and effect across lifetimes. This particular text opens at Rājagṛha, where the Buddha's monks, troubled by the passing into nirvāṇa of the two great disciples Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana, seek the Blessed One's guidance on matters of doubt. It is catalogued as Toh 348 in the Kangyur, the collection of canonical texts attributed to the Buddha himself, and falls within the broader category of avadāna literature found in that collection. The text was translated from Sanskrit into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Jinamitra together with the great-revision translator, the monk Devacandra.

The recitation of the avadāna is complete.

Translated by the Indian preceptor Jinamitra and the great-revision translator, the monk Devacandra, and definitively established.

In the language of India: Candraprabha Avadāna. In the Tibetan language: The Narrative of the Deeds of Moonlight.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

The Blessed One, the buddha, was dwelling at Rājagṛha in the Kalandaka Grove of the Bamboo Forest. At the time when the venerable monk Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana both passed completely into nirvāṇa, into the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder, the monks were filled with doubt, and they addressed the Blessed One, the buddha who dispels all doubt:

"Venerable One, how wondrous it is that these two chief disciples, Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana, could not endure this passing and entered complete nirvāṇa before the Buddha himself and before the Saṅgha of monks."

The Blessed One declared: "Monks, since Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana were fully free from attachment, free from aversion, free from delusion, free from birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, displeasure, and distress, what is so wondrous about their having entered nirvāṇa before the Buddha and the Saṅgha of monks? Now hear this: in the past, when Śāriputra

and Maudgalyāyana still possessed attachment, aversion, and delusion, still subject to birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, displeasure, and distress, they were so filled with sincere faith and devotion toward me alone that they could not bear to witness my death, and so they passed away first, transcended entirely beyond the desire realm, and were reborn in the world of Brahmā.

Monks, long ago, in times past, in the northern region there was a royal palace called Excellent Stone, a place of prosperity and abundance, pleasant and auspicious, filled with great multitudes of people and throngs of beings. Its moat measured twelve yojanas in length and twelve yojanas in breadth, making it perfectly square and most magnificently adorned. It had ramparts and latticed windows, tall parapets fitted with lattice-work, market stalls, and was filled throughout with every manner of jewel. It was thronged with kings, ministers, householders, merchants, and the people of the surrounding countryside. The people abided by the rule of law. The sounds of lutes, flutes, drums, fine instruments, great drums, clay drums, long drums, and conches rang out with certainty and regularity.

Monks, in that royal palace there drifted at all times the fragrances of eaglewood, aquilaria, sandalwood, fine powder, saffron, and sweet-smelling flowers — such a variety of scents carried by the wind, rising and moving through the streets and avenues, at the crossroads and at the three-way junctions. The palace was beautified with elephants, horses, chariots, and assemblies of foot soldiers, with mounts and vehicles, and the nearby streets and great roads were made beautiful. It was adorned with parasols, victory banners, and raised flags; with ramparts, latticed windows, parapets, and hanging half-moons, making it as lovely as the abode of the gods. It was endowed with lakes and ponds and pools and springs and cascading streams, which welled up from the lord of nāgas and the king of mountains, making it most beautifully adorned. It had blue lotuses, pink lotuses, white lotuses,

covered with white lotuses (puṇḍarīka), with sāla trees, palm trees, tamāla trees, donga trees, aśoka trees, tilaka trees, pūrṇaka trees, campaka trees, vakula trees, atimuktaka trees, and tamāla blossoms covering everything all around. In the groves of trees, kalapingka birds, parrots, śārikā birds, cuckoos, peacocks, and jīvañjīvaka birds filled the air with their calls. Beautified by all manner of trees in the near surroundings, it was made most delightful. In front lay a pleasure grove of great beauty, and monks, the palace of Rocasana was thus utterly delightful.

Monks, in that palace of Rocasana there lived a king named Candrababha — handsome of form, beautiful and lovely to behold, mindful of his past lives, endowed with divine sight, a wheel-turning monarch of a single continent, a righteous king, a dharma-king, who held sovereign lordship over the kingdom of Jambudvīpa. Monks, because King Candrababha possessed his own radiance, whenever he went there was no darkness. He had no need to carry before him the light of precious jewels, the light of oil lamps, or the light of torches. Monks, rather, light issued forth from King Candrababha's own body, just as light radiates from the disc of the moon — from his body in the same way light shone forth. It was for this reason that King Candrababha came to bear the name Candrababha, Moonlight.

Now at that very time and in that very age, throughout this Jambudvīpa, beginning with the palace of Rocasana, there came to be sixty-eight thousand cities — prosperous, pleasant, blessed with good harvests, filled with many people and densely populated. Monks, moreover, the people of Jambudvīpa under King Candrababha had no taxes, no gambling debts, no toll-levies. They enjoyed the abundance of the fields; the people were peaceful and dwelt amid the sounds of domestic happiness; the villages, towns, and market settlements were filled with assemblies of people together with kings and royal families.

Monks, at that very time and in that very age, the lifespan of the people of Jambudvīpa was forty-four thousand years.

Monks, King Candrababha, who was a bodhisattva, was one who gave all things and relinquished all things completely. He departed from the palace of Rocasana and went to the eastern quarter of the city, where he raised parasols, victory banners, and flags, and having beaten a great golden drum with full and proper strokes, he gave gifts and made merit. Likewise in the south, the west, and the north of the city he gave gifts and made merit. And at the crossroads at the center too he gave gifts and made merit — namely: to those who desired food, food; to those who desired drink, drink; and he gave forth and made merit with food and delicacies, garlands, oil lamps, incense, ointments, beds, seats, and backrests; dwellings for the people, parasols, carriages, footwear, ornaments; silver vessels filled to the brim with gold dust, gold vessels filled to the brim with silver dust; cattle adorned with golden horns; lacquer vessels; and young women arrayed in every adornment.

Garments of many colors from many lands of many kinds — silks, Chinese silks, precious fabrics, fine cotton muslin (dugula), deer-hide cloth, Bāhlika cloth, linen, precious stones, gold, gold-embroidered clothing, Kāśikā silk, and silken garments and the rest — these too he gave in gift and made merit.

Monks, whatever gifts King Moonlight gave were enough to make all the people of Jambudvīpa wealthy, possessed of great riches, and possessed of great abundance — so great were the gifts he gave.

Monks, through whatever gifts of elephants, horses, carriages, parasols, and the like that King Moonlight gave, there was not a single person in Jambudvīpa who went about on foot — so great were the gifts he gave, until all the people of Jambudvīpa rode upon the backs of elephants and atop four-horsed carriages, bearing parasols of gold and silver, and proceeded from garden to garden, from district to district, from city to city.

Monks, then King Moonlight thought to himself: what is the point of merely giving these gifts? I shall give to all the people of Jambudvīpa the very garments, ornaments, and adornments that I myself wear, so that all the people of Jambudvīpa may delight and revel in royal splendor. And so King Moonlight gave to all the people of Jambudvīpa crowns, silks, garments, ornaments, and adornments — namely, necklaces, bracelets, armlets, garlands, pendants, hanging strings of pearls, and all things befitting a king — and gave these gifts in full.

Monks, through King Moonlight's giving in full of things befitting a king — garments, ornaments, crowns, and silks — all the people of Jambudvīpa came to wear crowns and to bind their hair with trailing silk. Just as King Moonlight appeared, so did all the people of Jambudvīpa appear, and in this way he gave in full.

Monks, King Moonlight had a proclamation sounded by drum throughout the royal palace Rocana, declaring: all you people of Jambudvīpa, delight and revel in royal splendor for as long as I shall live. Monks, when all the people of Jambudvīpa heard this proclamation of King Moonlight, they all entered into royal delight and reveling, and the sound of music arose — lutes, flutes, barrel drums, sweet-voiced instruments, three-stringed lutes, long drums, clay drums, a thousand conches, and the sound of nearly a hundred cymbals — and adorned with armlets, garlands, pendants, jewels, and pearl ornaments, and with earrings, and arrayed in their adornments, surrounded by assemblies of women, they came to enjoy the splendor of royal sovereignty.

And then at that very time, in the royal palace Rocana, the people reveled in royal delight, and the sound of lutes, flutes, barrel drums, sweet-voiced instruments, three-stringed lutes, clay drums, long drums, and conches resounded through the sixty-eight thousand cities. And wherever the great golden drums were beaten at the four stations of King Moonlight's giving, a sound of such pleasing quality arose as this: it was like the sound of song, dance, and music resounding in the divine city of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.

Monks, in just this way, at that very time, all the people of Jambudvīpa were settled together in happiness and became greatly joyful amidst the sounds of song, dance, and music.

At that time, in the royal palace of King Moonlight, there dwelt seven billion, one hundred and seventy-two thousand people.

Monks, by his very nature King Moonlight was handsome, pleasing to look upon, and beautiful. Beyond that, the sight of him brought delight to great multitudes of people. Furthermore, when men and women beheld him, they were filled with a joy that never grew weary of looking. Whenever King Moonlight went forth from the city to his stations of giving, countless hundreds of thousands of millions of living beings would gaze upon him and speak thus: "O what wonder! This King Moonlight must be a god who has come and is reigning as king in this Jambudvīpa. For the form, color, and shape of King Moonlight cannot belong to any human being of Jambudvīpa." In whichever direction he looked, thousands of women gazed back in that very direction, and any woman who came near him was considered truly fortunate. Others said, "It is only those with pure minds who may draw close to him; not others. This King Moonlight is to be regarded as a god's equal."

Monks, King Moonlight had thirteen thousand five hundred ministers. Among all those ministers, two were preeminent: the ministers named Excellent Moon and Earth-Holder, renowned for their wisdom, possessed of keen intelligence, exercising authority over all affairs, cherishing the king, protecting the king entirely, and performing every last duty of the king's affairs with a heart that held nothing back. The foremost minister, Excellent Moon, would cause all the human beings of Jambudvīpa to correctly take up and abide by the path of the ten virtuous actions for as long as they lived, saying to them, "You people of Jambudvīpa, rightly take up and dwell in this path of the ten virtuous actions for as long as you live." Thus he would engage all the people of Jambudvīpa

correctly in the path of the ten virtuous actions. Monks, the foremost minister, the great Excellent Moon, was such that he would teach and demonstrate instructions of this kind.

Monks, now the wheel-turning king Moonlight had come to feel deep affection, joy, and delight toward the foremost minister, the great Excellent Moon. Moreover, when the king looked upon the color, form, and shape of Excellent Moon, he was never sated; he would not part from him even for a single moment.

Then, on another occasion, the foremost minister, the great Excellent Moon, dreamed that flesh-eating demons of dark hue had seized the crown from the head of King Moonlight. He awoke from the dream in a state of terror and dread, his hair standing on end, and thought: "Surely someone must be coming to take the head of King Moonlight. The king is one who gives all, who relinquishes all — there is no one else who would withhold from and refuse to give completely to the lowly, the helpless, the destitute, the suffering, and those who beg. I shall not report this dream to King Moonlight. Instead I will have heads fashioned of precious materials, and store them in the treasury and the vaults, so that if anyone ever comes to demand a divine head, those heads of precious substance may be used to satisfy the demand." And so he had heads fashioned from precious substances and stored them in the treasuries and vaults.

Then, on yet another occasion, the foremost minister Earth-Holder dreamed that the precious gem-heads of King Moonlight split apart into a hundred pieces. Again he was filled with fear and dread and deep anxiety, thinking, "Could it be that King Moonlight will be deposed from his kingdom, or that some harm will come to his very life?" He then summoned skilled brahmin astrologers and dream-interpreters, and said: "I have had a dream of this kind — tell me by divination what the result of this dream will be." The interpreters replied:

Not long after seeing such a dream, there will come certain ones who raise the heads of gods. This is what the dream portends.

Upon hearing those words, the foremost minister Earth-Holder placed his hands on his sides and stood there sunk in the deepest anxiety, thinking: King Moonlight, embodied in loving-kindness, filled with compassion, a source of delight to all sentient beings — how very quickly does the power of impermanence draw near.

Then on yet another occasion, all thirteen thousand five hundred ministers had a dream of this kind: they dreamed that yakṣas (Skt. yakṣa) holding skulls in their hands had toppled the parasols, banners, and victory standards at the four giving-halls of King Moonlight, and had smashed the great golden drums. Again filled with fear, dread, and deep distress, they thought: Will King Moonlight, ruler of the great earth, embodied in loving-kindness, filled with compassion, a source of delight to all sentient beings, depart through the power of impermanence? Will we be separated from dwelling together with the gods, scattered apart, dispersed, cut off from their company? Will the people of Jambudvīpa be left without refuge or ally?

When King Moonlight heard this, he had it proclaimed by drum throughout sixty-eight thousand cities: "You people of Jambudvīpa, for as long as you live, take your joy and sport in the royal splendor. What use is it to set your minds upon a dream that is like an illusion?"

When the proclamation of King Moonlight was heard, all the people of Jambudvīpa began to sport and revel to the sounds of great cymbals, lutes, flutes, small hand-drums, melodious instruments, three-stringed lutes, clay drums, long drums, and music from what seemed like a thousand conches. Women adorned with golden head-ornaments, necklaces, pearl earrings, and every kind of decoration, surrounded by throngs of their companions, gave themselves over to enjoying the royal splendor.

At that same time and in that same period, throughout Jambudvīpa there was the sound of song, dance, and music, and in all sixty-eight thousand cities flutes were surely blown. At the four great giving-halls the great golden drums were beaten, and a sound arose that was sweet and pleasing, resounding throughout all of Jambudvīpa — like the sound of song, dance, and music echoing within the celestial palace of the gods of the Thirty-Three.

At that same time and in that same period, there lived on Fragrance-Rising Mountain a brahmin named Fierce-Eye who possessed knowledge of illusory arts. Fierce-Eye heard that at the palace of Fine Stone a king named Moonlight gave everything to all. Having heard this, he thought to himself: If I go and present my request, and if he truly gives everything, then he will give to me as well. But otherwise — to give away the head, the supreme limb, which is dear and precious and beloved and a source of great joy — this is difficult, this is without precedent, this is without opportunity. And so he came down from Fragrance-Rising Mountain.

Then a goddess dwelling on that mountain of rising fragrance began to weep, and cried out: "Alas! King Moonlight, embodied in loving-kindness, filled with compassion, a source of delight to all sentient beings — how painful it is that the power of impermanence draws so near to you!"

And at that same time and in that same period, all of Jambudvīpa became enveloped in a rain of darkness.

The whole of Jambudvīpa was shaken and utterly convulsed, and shooting stars fell, and the directions blazed, and the gods in the sky between gave way to sorrow.

At that same time and in that same period, not far at all from the royal palace of Bright Stone, there dwelt a forest-sage (ṛṣi) named Variegated-Friend, possessing the five higher knowledges (abhijñā), whose very nature was loving-kindness and compassion, and who was pleasing and gentle toward all sentient beings. He dwelt there surrounded by five hundred attendants.

Then that sage, seeing all of Jambudvīpa shaken and utterly convulsed, spoke to his retinue:

"All of Jambudvīpa has now become wrapped in a rain of darkness, shaken and utterly convulsed. The sun and the moon alike shine neither brightly, nor clearly, nor steadily. Do you understand, children? Without question, some great being is about to pass away.

See how the hosts of kinnaras and the gods of the forest weep aloud.

Even the gods dwelling in the sky above pour forth their lament.

The moon is robbed of its radiance, and the sun itself of its light.

Today the drums are beaten, yet no pleasing sound arises.

These very groves of flowering, fruit-laden trees

fall to the ground though no wind has stirred them.

Since this dreadful sound is heard everywhere throughout the land, it is plain that inexhaustible suffering is about to arise in the city.

Because of this, every last person dwelling in the city

is struck through with suffering in their heart,

wailing and beating their hands against their chests.

Their hair hangs loose, their speech is broken,

women with moon-like faces weep without restraint,

and all who dwell in the city cry out with heartfelt grief.

These very clouds thunder without sending down rain,

and the bodies of water nearby have nearly run dry.

Mountains and forests blaze in terrible fire,
and people weep, stricken with great anguish in their own homes.
The earth trembles like a boat driven by the wind upon the water,
and a wind rises, mingling with a dust of exceeding roughness.

The signs of misfortune are now many here in this very place, and therefore it is entirely fitting that we go in the direction of good omen."

Furthermore, children: though the great golden kettledrum at King Moonlight's four giving-stations has been struck, no pleasing sound has arisen. Therefore, without question, great calamity is about to befall that royal palace of Bright Stone.

Then the sage of fierce eyes set out for the royal palace of Bright Stone. At that very time, the goddess dwelling in the city saw the sage of fierce eyes from a great distance, and went directly to where King Moonlight was. She came before King Moonlight and spoke these words to him:

"Let the king, whom the gods cherish, be informed. Today there will come one who raises the head of gods, who brings suffering fully to account, who looks for his opportunity — one who will sever the head of a god. Therefore, for the sake of compassion toward sentient beings, may the king protect himself utterly."

Then King Moonlight, hearing that a head-raiser had come, was filled with great joy and wonder, and his eyes opened wide. He said to the goddess: "Goddess, go without fear. If he has indeed come, I shall bring to perfect fulfillment the long-cherished aspiration of my heart."

Then the goddess, knowing that King Moonlight was intent on this course of action, was stricken with grief and distress, and vanished from that very spot.

Then King Moonlight thought to himself: "What is so very wonderful about my having given wealth, gold, and food to those who desired food? I shall give even my own body entirely to those who beg of me."

Then the brahmin Fierce-Eye entered through the southern gate of the city. The goddess of the city turned him back, saying: "Evil brahmin, do not enter — go back! You deluded man, how can you, with a mind bent on severing, act against King Moonlight, who is loving-kindness itself, filled with compassion, endowed with immeasurable and perfect qualities, who governs the whole of Jambudvīpa, who is without fault and does no harm? Evil brahmin, do not enter

— go back!"

King Moonlight heard these words and thought to himself: "My supplicant has been stopped by the goddess at the city gate." He then said to his chief minister, Great Moon: "Let Great Moon know this: my supplicant has been stopped by the goddess at the city gate. Go, bring him before me directly. So does the king request." Obedient to King Moonlight's words, the chief minister Great Moon went to the city gate. The goddess of the city turned him away, saying: "Let the goddess know this: summon this brahmin — release this brahmin and let him pass."

Then the goddess dwelling in the city spoke thus to Great Moon: "Let Great Moon know this: this brahmin comes to the palace Rodrazang with a savage mind, a mind without compassion, and an unbearable mind, intent on destroying King Moonlight. What could one of such vile character do for you? He will go before King Moonlight and beg for his head."

Then the chief minister Great Moon said to the goddess: "Goddess, I have thought of a means by which this brahmin will not be able to take the king's head." Thereupon the chief minister Great Moon led Fierce-Eye the brahmin inside and, entering the city, spoke to the keeper of the treasury: "Bring here heads fashioned from precious jewels, and I shall give them to this brahmin." The keeper of the treasury then amassed a great heap of jeweled heads at the palace gate. The chief minister Great Moon presented the jewel-fashioned heads to Fierce-Eye the brahmin, saying: "Great brahmin, take as many jeweled heads as you wish, and we will give you whatever wealth and gold you need — take it and go. This will provide your livelihood unto your children's children's generation. What use is a head full of skull, bone, brain matter, and marrow? What use is that to you?"

At these words, Fierce-Eye the brahmin said to Great Moon: "Let Great Moon know this: I have no need of jeweled heads, nor do I need gold or wealth. Rather, I have come before this great sovereign of the earth, this one who gives all, for the sake of begging his head."

At these words, the chief minister Great Moon and the earth-guardian placed their hands on each other's shoulders, thinking: "Now the time has come," and stood there, sunk in deep distress.

Then King Moonlight, having heard all this nearby, sent a messenger to summon the chief minister Great Moon and the earth-guardian, and spoke thus: "Bring that brahmin to me. I shall bring to perfect fulfillment the

long-cherished aspiration of my heart." At these words, the chief minister Great Moon and the earth-guardian, their faces streaming with tears like rain, cried out with voices of grief and lamentation:

"This one who embodies the very nature of the god Loving-kindness (Maitreya), who is filled with compassion, who is gentle and pleasing to all sentient beings, who is endowed with immeasurable and perfect qualities, who is skilled in wisdom, who possesses the divine eye — this one has now come to stand close to the power of impermanence. From this day we shall be parted from our god, separated, changed, severed, and divided one from another." With these thoughts, they touched their heads to the feet of the king and sat to one side.

Then King Moonlight, wishing to give with totality, to give in an utterly extraordinary way, to give all things completely, spoke at last to that brahmin, saying: "Brahmin, come here. Take what you have come to beg." Then the brahmin Fierce-Eye went to where King Moonlight was, and having approached, he greeted King Moonlight with words of victory and long life, and spoke to King Moonlight thus:

A bodhisattva rejoices in giving away all things.

O virtuous bodhisattva, you abide in the spotless Dharma.

By the intention of the holy omniscient one who longs for awakening, you whose very nature is compassion — grant me your head, O compassionate one.

Then King Moonlight, having heard such words spoken by the brahmin, was filled with the utmost joy, and with eyes brightened by that joy, he said to the brahmin Fierce-Eye:

Though I am an only son, born of a father,
even so, take this head of mine.

May your wish come to full fruition,
and through this gift of my head, may awakening be attained.

My head, with its brain, blood, and marrow,
serves no purpose for any work you desire —
yet take it; whatever need you have of my head,
may your hope be fulfilled and may you rejoice.

O great brahmin, take away this supreme member of my body, this head,
carefully and without obstruction.

Having said this, he himself removed the crown from his head.

O monks, the very instant King Moonlight removed the crown from his head, all the crowns upon the heads of every person in Jambudvīpa also fell. From the four directions of the royal palace of Good Stones, meteors fell. And the goddess of the city proclaimed aloud: "The evil brahmin is about to cut off the head of this King Moonlight!"

Then the chief minister Great Moon and the earth-guardian, knowing that King Moonlight was in this way giving away his very own body, approached the king's feet with faces streaming with tears like a flooded land, and said: "This one whom even the gods behold is a man of great fortune born into this world." And the two of them, gazing at him with minds of manifest faith, generated a mind of loving-kindness toward the brahmin Fierce-Eye, and thinking that they could not bear to look upon the impermanence of their divine lord, in that very instant they passed away, completely transcended all of the desire realm, and were born in the Brahma world.

Then the yakṣas dwelling on the earth and the yakṣas roaming through the sky, learning of this act of striving by King Moonlight, began to cry out in lamentation: "Alas! Now King Moonlight is about to give away his body — how terrible!" And at the gate of the royal palace, many hundreds and thousands of living creatures gathered together.

Then the brahmin Fierce-Eye, seeing that great crowd of people assembled, spoke thus to King Moonlight: "If your divine majesty would be so gracious, I would not hesitate to take the divine head before this great gathering of people. If your majesty would give away your head entirely —"

"Let the two of us withdraw to a secluded place." When he had spoken thus, King Moonlight said to the brahmin Fierce-Eye: "Great brahmin, so be it. May all your wishes and the hopes of your heart be completely fulfilled."

Now, monks, within the royal palace of Stonewalled City, there was a pleasure grove called Jewel and Precious Essence, adorned all around with many kinds of trees, delightful and charming, where mynah birds, śārikā birds, cuckoos, peacocks, the shangshang bird, and kalavinka birds sang their sweet and pleasing songs. In the midst of that joyful forest grove, at the center of a terrace in that pleasure garden, there grew a campaka tree in full and constant bloom.

Then King Moonlight rose from the royal throne, took up a sharp sword, and went to that pleasure grove of Jewel and Precious Essence.

Now when the many hundreds and thousands of living creatures in the city of Stonewalled Palace saw King Moonlight enter upon this act of striving, they began crying out in lamentation and followed after him. King Moonlight, seeing that great crowd of people gathered there in lamentation, spoke briefly to console them and to give them courage: "Be diligent in virtuous qualities," he taught them thus. Then, taking the brahmin Fierce-Eye by the hand, he entered the pleasure grove of Jewel and Precious Essence.

The very moment King Moonlight entered the pleasure grove of Jewel and Precious Essence, all the victory banners and pennants of the royal palace of Stonewalled City bowed in the direction of that pleasure grove.

Then King Moonlight closed the gate of the pleasure grove of Jewel and Precious Essence, and said to the brahmin: "Great brahmin, take this supreme limb of mine."

When he had spoken thus, the brahmin Fierce-Eye said to King Moonlight: "I have not the slightest hesitation in cutting off the divine head."

When he had spoken thus, King Moonlight, holding the sharp sword, went to the place in that grove where the campaka tree bloomed in all seasons. Then the goddess of that pleasure grove, knowing that King Moonlight was about to give away his very self in this way, began to cry out in lamentation and said these words: "You wicked brahmin — how can you cut off the head of this King Moonlight, who is without fault, without harm, endowed with immeasurable virtues?"

Then King Moonlight turned the goddess of the pleasure grove away, saying: "Goddess, do not create an obstacle to my offering of this supreme limb. Why is that? Goddess, in a former time, when I was offering this supreme limb — my head — a certain goddess created an obstacle, and through that act great demerit arose for that goddess, while for me the attainment of unsurpassable gnosis was delayed for a very long time. Goddess, right here in this very pleasure grove of Jewel and Precious Essence, I have already given away a head's worth of heads in full sacrifice, and not once did anyone create an obstacle for me. Therefore, goddess, do not create an obstacle to my offering of this supreme limb. Goddess, this is the very place where, by giving away my body completely to a tigress in a single act of total self-surrender, I caused the bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-kindness), who had fallen back from the path for forty aeons, to return to it."

Then the goddess, seeing that great miraculous power of King Moonlight, was filled with deep joy toward the king, and fell silent, speaking not a word.

Then King Moonlight entered upon a true and sincere aspiration, and spoke these words: "You gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (dri za), and kiṃnaras (mi'am ci) who dwell in this assembly of the pleasure grove — be witness! Here in this pleasure grove I perform the act of giving, the supreme giving of all, the utterly transcendent giving, the giving that is the complete surrender of my own head. And this giving of my head is not for the sake of kingship, not for the sake of the higher realms, not for the sake of Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), not for the sake of Māra, not for the sake of Brahmā, not for the sake of dominion over a wheel-turning realm. Rather, it is so that, having fully and completely awakened to the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening right here, I may tame those sentient beings not yet tamed, liberate those not yet liberated, free those not yet freed, bring relief to those not yet relieved, and lead to complete nirvāṇa those not yet completely passed beyond sorrow. By this truth and by these words of truth, may my toil bear fruit. And after I have passed completely beyond sorrow, may relics the size of a single mustard seed arise. And may a great stūpa, surpassing all other stūpas, arise in the center of this garden of jewels and precious gems — so that whatever sentient beings come wearily to pay homage to that great stūpa, and behold it, surpassing all other stūpas, enshrining those relics, may become free of weariness. And when, freed of weariness, multitudes of people come and make offerings at my stūpa, may they too be turned toward the higher realms and toward liberation."

Having said this, he tied his topknot to the campaka tree, then called the brahmin and said: "Great brahmin, come here. Without making any obstruction, cut off and take my head."

Then King Moonlight, with his own body's power and strength fully arisen, generated toward that brahmin a mind of great compassion together with loving-kindness that arises and departs with all beings, and had his head cut off. He gave it to the fierce brahmin's eyes. When he passed, he transcended entirely the world of Brahmā and was born among the gods of the Subhṛtsnā heaven, the realm of exceedingly expansive virtue.

O monks, in the very moment that the head was fully given over, this great trichiliocosm trembled, shook thoroughly, heaved and heaved again, swayed and swayed thoroughly. The gods dwelling in the midst of space cried out

"Ālālā!" The gods of the intermediate sky scattered divine blue lotuses, red lotuses, white day-blooming lotuses, and white night-blooming lotuses, and scattered powdered aloe wood, powdered tagara, and powdered sandalwood, and scattered the divine flowers mādārava and great mādārava, and also rained down a shower of garments. The sound of divine music was beaten out in full.

Then the fierce brahmin took the head and left the garden of jewels and precious gems, and the many hundreds and thousands of living creatures gathered there cried out in pain "Alas!" — some fell and rolled upon the ground, some stretched out their arms and lamented aloud, and women tore their hair and wept. The many hundreds and thousands of living creatures also came together, gathered in that very place, and there in that place they cultivated meditative concentration, and passing away right there, they were born with the same fortune as King Moonlight among the gods of the realm of exceedingly expansive virtue. Some cultivated meditative concentration and, passing away in that very place, were born among the gods of the realm of luminosity.

Others gathered together and, using the fragrant wood of King Moonlight's body — adorned with every mark of fragrance — they cremated him. His bones were then placed in a golden urn, and at a crossroads on the great road a reliquary stupa was ceremoniously erected for his bodily remains. Parasols, victory banners, and pennants were raised, and offerings were made with perfumes, garlands, powdered incense, and music. With a mind of pure and single-pointed faith directed toward King Moonlight, and with that same sense of grief, they aroused meditative concentration. Through the meditative concentration they had thus aroused, they passed away and were born in the Brahmā world. Some, overwhelmed by grief at not having seen King Moonlight, passed away and were born among the six classes of gods in the desire realm. All those who died there, every one of them, came to be inclined toward the higher realms and toward liberation.

O monks, at that time and in that era, the northern royal palace that became Dotsang — do not regard it as anything other than this very Dotsang, for at that time and in that era it was the royal palace Dotsang.

O monks, what do you think? He who was called King Moonlight — that was I. At that time and in that era, having entered into the conduct of a bodhisattva, it was I myself who, in the garden of jewels and precious essences, gave his

head along with his eyes to the fierce brahmin.

O monks, what do you think? He who was called the fierce brahmin's eye — that was Devadatta, for at that time and in that era he became the fierce brahmin's eye.

O monks, what do you think? At that time and in that era, the foremost minister called Great Moon and the earth-holder — these two were none other than the monks Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana. These two, unable to bear my passing into nirvāṇa, themselves passed away first, before they could witness my own death. Even now they cannot bear my passing into nirvāṇa, and before witnessing my passing into nirvāṇa, they themselves will first pass into nirvāṇa.

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One's monks rejoiced and gave fervent praise to what the Blessed One had taught.

The Account of King Moonlight's Realization is complete.

From the Indian master —

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the final line, ending in the middle of a list of lotus flowers. The passage continues beyond what was provided. The colophon at the opening refers to the conclusion of a prior avadāna, and the new text beginning here is the Candraprabha Avadāna, a narrative from the avadāna literature. The translator Jinamitra is a well-attested Indian paṇḍita who worked in Tibet during the early translation period; Devacandra is his Tibetan collaborator.

- The bird name "འགྲོ་མཁའ་མཁའ་" (śaṅśaṅteu) is the Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit jīvañjīvaka, a two-headed or mythic bird of the Indian tradition, here rendered accordingly.

The place-name "Rocasana" for "འགྲོ་མཁའ་" (literally "Good Stone" or "Fine Rock") follows the convention of the preceding passage; it may be a translation of an underlying Sanskrit name such as Śilāmaṅgala or similar — the exact Sanskrit is uncertain but the rendering is kept consistent with the prior passage.

The term "dugula" (འགྲོ་མཁའ་) is a transliteration of Sanskrit dukūla, a type of fine cloth often rendered as muslin or bark-cloth; the parenthetical gloss is offered for clarity.

- The palace name rendered here as Rocana translates the Tibetan "rdo bzangs" literally as "excellent stone" or "fine stone"; this may correspond to a Sanskrit palace name such as Rocana or a similar term. The precise Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain, but the name is treated as a proper noun throughout and rendered consistently.

The "four stations of giving" refers to four designated distribution points established by King Moonlight for his great gift-giving, a detail elaborated elsewhere in the sūtra.

- The phrase rendered "thirteen thousand five hundred ministers" reflects the Tibetan number compound stong phrag phyed dang bcu gsum, literally "thirteen and a half thousands," i.e., 13,500. This is an unusual but straightforward reading.

The term rendered "flesh-eating demons of dark hue" translates du ba'i mdog can gyi sha za, literally "smoke-colored flesh-eaters," a class of demonic being.

- The phrase rendered "ones who raise the heads of gods" translates a somewhat elliptical Tibetan expression. In context it almost certainly refers to emissaries or agents of a god — most likely Śiva in his wrathful aspect — who will demand the king's head. The image anticipates the narrative to come, in which the brahmin Fierce-Eye acts as such an agent. The expression is left as it stands since it is part of the dream-interpretation and is deliberately oracular.

The phrase "pearl earrings" for "se mo do'i nor bu'i rna rgyan" is an approximation; the compound may refer to a specific ornament type whose exact form is uncertain, but "pearl earrings" fits the jewelry context well.

- The epithet "fierce eyes" for the sage's name is a rendering of the Tibetan personal name Drag po'i mig, meaning literally "Eyes of Fierceness" or "Fierce-Eyed." This is the sage's proper name, not a generic description, and is rendered descriptively since no standard Sanskrit equivalent is recoverable from context alone.

The phrase rendered "one who raises the head of gods" and "sever the head of a god" refers to the imminent arrival of a brahmin who will beg for King Moonlight's head — a motif central to the jātaka narrative. The goddess's warning plays on the ambiguity of "raising" (presenting, exalting) and the actual deed of severing. The translation preserves this deliberate ambiguity as found in the source.

- The palace name here rendered as "Rodrazang" is a transliteration of རོད་རྩ་མཚོ་ (literally "Good Stone" or "Fine Stone"), which appears to be a proper name for the royal palace. No standard Sanskrit equivalent is established in this context, so it is retained in transliteration.
- The phrase rendered "god Loving-kindness (Maitreya)" translates the Tibetan literally as "one who has the nature of the god Maitreya," functioning as a laudatory epithet of the bodhisattva king rather than a direct identification with the future buddha Maitreya; the honorific force is preserved in the rendering.

The final sentence of the passage is syntactically incomplete in the Tibetan as given, ending mid-conditional clause. This is noted here rather than flagged in the body; the translation renders what is present.

- The phrase translated as "a head's worth of heads" renders the Tibetan "mgo stong snyed yongs su gtong ba," literally "giving away as many as a thousand heads." This is the standard bodhisattva narrative trope of innumerable head-gifts and has been rendered to capture the cumulative sense naturally in speech.

The bird called "shangshang" is a mythical creature, sometimes described as half-human half-bird; it is left untranslated as it is a proper Tibetan term for a legendary being with no clean English equivalent.

- The divine realms mentioned at the end require clarification. The Tibetan "དགེ་རྒྱ་ལྷ་འདྲེན་གྱི་ལྷ་རྣམས་" (dge rgyas kyi lha rnam) refers to a specific class of gods in the form realm. The term "dge rgyas" renders the Sanskrit Subhṛtsna, the third of the third-dhyāna heavens, characterized by pervasive virtue or well-being. The "འོད་གསལ་གྱི་ལྷ་འདྲེན་གྱི་ལྷ་རྣམས་" (od gsal gyi lha'i ris) refers to the Ābhāsvara gods, the highest level of the second dhyāna realm, here translated as "the realm of luminosity." The juxtaposition of these two destinations for different groups of beings, with the king reborn in the higher Subhṛtsna and some animals in the lower Ābhāsvara, may seem doctrinally unexpected; it likely reflects the different degrees of meditative absorption achieved.

- The final line "འོད་གསལ་གྱི་ལྷ་འདྲེན་གྱི་ལྷ་རྣམས་" is the opening of the standard colophon identifying the

Indian paṇḍita involved in the translation; the passage breaks off here and has been rendered accordingly as "From the Indian master —" to indicate the incomplete colophon.

The phrase rendered "fierce brahmin's eye" is a slightly unusual construction; in context it refers to the brahmin named Fierce Eye (Dragpo'i mig, roughly "Savage Eye"), confirming that Devadatta played this role in a past life. This is consistent with standard Jātaka-style narrative theology in which past-life counterparts of disciples and antagonists are identified at the story's close.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.